



... and SMALL

Around 97 percent of animals are **INVERTEBRATES**—creatures without a backbone. Not only that, they don't have a bony skeleton or proper jaws either. Instead, many rely on a hard outer covering (exoskeleton) to support their body, or have a shell for protection. There are more than 30 large groups of invertebrates—here are a few that you may have come across.

INSECTS

Number of species: more than 1,100,000

KEY FEATURES



Paired jointed legs



Compound eyes



Hard exoskeleton



Many have wings



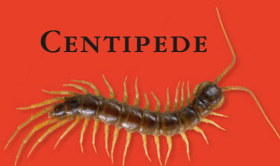
Insects are the largest and probably the most successful group of animals on Earth. They were the first organisms to fly, which enabled them to colonize many new environments. When insects emerge from the egg, some, for example butterflies, have a completely different body structure from their adult form. They have to go through a stage called metamorphosis, where their body is broken down and reassembled. Others, such as grasshoppers, go through a process of splitting off their exoskeleton as they grow bigger.

LADYBUGS

BEETLE



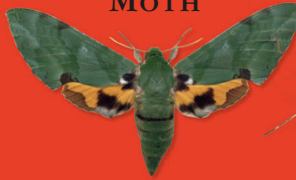
CENTIPEDE



BUTTERFLY



MOTH



STICK INSECT

CRUSTACEANS

Number of species: 47,000

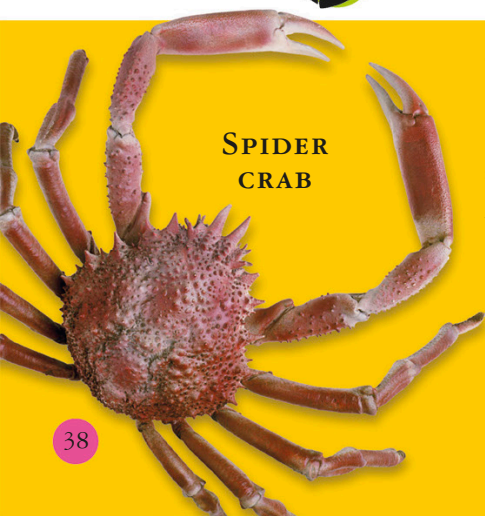
KEY FEATURES



Jointed legs



Hard exoskeleton



SPIDER CRAB



LOBSTER



SHRIMP



WOOD LOUSE

HERMIT CRAB



Crustaceans are mainly found in the water, although wood lice live on land. Crustaceans are related to insects but have a less obviously segmented body. Some segments are fused together to form a single piece, which gives better protection for their eyes and head. Although lobsters and crabs have menacing claws, these are used for defense rather than attacking prey. Most feed on the remains of other animals or particles floating through the water.